BOOKS

Remembrance of Things Art

Despite the lack of archival material, the book manages to piece together a portrait of artist and sculptor Leela Mukherjee



LEELA MUKHERJEE: A GUILELESS MODERNIST
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ments and traditions.

As the book repeatedly points out, Leela learnt to sculpt in wood not in Santiniketan, where she met her husband, but later in 1948 in Nepal, when he was appointed curator of the government museum. Benodebehari encouraged Leela to study carving under the Nepali artisan Kulasundar Shilakarmi, and she continued to work in the medium till the early 1980s, when the physical work started taking a toll on her body. Perhaps, further research on Leela's time in Nepal, the pedagogical approach of Shilakarmi, and her subsequent intellectual interests might help to delineate a chronological progression of her work.

Some of the most engaging parts of the book are those based on impressions and memories. We learn from artist Ranbir Kaleka, who was a tenant at her house in Delhi in the early 1980s, that "a mere few minutes after waking up in the early hours to shower", Leela would "wear a crisp sari, and get her drawing and watercolour pad along with brushes and pencils into her shoulder bag" to go to the nearby park to draw the grooming routines of house help or go further on to see migrant women labourers setting off for construction sites. In Leela's drawings, these women acquire a mythical character, but their inspiration came from daily life in the city. Artist Nilima Sheikh describes a visit to her house around then: "A little daunted by the mountains of paper spilling over the tables in her home, I nevertheless set to the task of unrolling endless rolls of paper. As image after image pranced out, I was led first by their exuberance and ingenuous spontaneity into a place in the world they made for Leela Mukherjee." This world had remnants of Santiniketan, but also contained traces of her sojourns to Triveni Kala Sangam, where she saw Manipuri dancers and rendered them on paper.

Leela would go to the park to draw the migrant workers. In her drawings, they acquired a mythical character

In these recollections of Leela Mukherjee late in her life, she seems to exude an artistic freedom that is commendable and advocates it even for those who were not exposed to the same influences as her. Sheikh writes, "I found a spirited, diehard nonconformist who lived and loved life on her own terms, even when she had to cope with its struggles and stress." ■

–Zeenat Nagree